

INTRODUCTION

As firms are exploring different ways to cut their environmental impacts, a carbon offset represents the removal of one metric ton of greenhouse gases through actions such as conservation and renewable energy expansion. However, despite their stated purpose, carbon offsets are not an effective tool to address climate change; instead they pose as a form of greenwashing.

Companies acquire these credits to satisfy their own emissions and claim “carbon neutrality”. Those in support of this argue that it brings cost-effectiveness into the global mission to lower emissions, while those against it argue that it overstates its environmental benefits, steers us from real decarbonization, and recreates global inequalities.

This paper argues that, although carbon offsets have environmental potential, the current structure functions predominantly as a means of greenwashing rather than an effective climate solution due to structural weaknesses, including the hyper-financialization of the natural world, and issues with global accountability/equity. These issues manifest in many African contexts where offsets simulate historical patterns of extraction. (Bassey 2023a; Bassey 2023b) To expand on this position, this paper will primarily examine the arguments in support of offsets, followed by an analysis of their imperfections.

ARGUMENTS IN FAVOR

(Those in support of carbon offsets mention two types of benefits; economic efficiency & positive externalities)

Those in support of carbon offsets argue that they have environmental and economic advantages. Firstly, they believe that offsets can reduce emissions in areas where it is cheaper to do so or where marginal abatement costs are low. This would suggest that the reduction of carbon dioxide would occur in developing countries as it will be cheaper to do so than reducing the same amount in a developed and industrialized nation. Because greenhouse gases mix globally, the location at which it is reduced is often overlooked. Many see reducing carbon dioxide output in

developing nations as an efficient way to reduce emissions. Those in support additionally believe that carbon offset projects provide positive externalities such as reforestation and the implementation of renewable energy projects, while simultaneously providing access to electricity and promoting public health providing financial incentives for projects that may have lacked funding. In turn, this is envisioned to promote global cooperation, granting developed nations the opportunity to lead projects in developing nations. Claims of these benefits are present in programs such as the Kasigau Corridor REDD++ and Mai Ndombe project. (Earthly Team. (n.d.))

Supporters tend to be very optimistic on the topic of offsets, as they believe it can create a win-win scenario where wealthy nations finance developing regions such as African and Latin American nations receive investments and restoration while global emissions decrease at a much lower cost.

CRITIQUES

In order to fully understand this debate, one must consider global perspectives and historical patterns of resource control. While carbon offsets claim to ensure climate benefits, they replicate patterns of extraction and global inequalities in several countries, primarily in Africa. Currently carbon offsets are a form of “carbon colonialism” where parts of African land are being used to clean up pollution emitted by western countries without benefit to African communities, essentially treating the natural world as tradable carbon assets (Bassey 2023a; Asiyanbi 2016).

These concerns are not theoretical. Many African projects involve acres of land designated to carbon sequestration. This land then becomes a vital part of the global carbon economy controlled by external actors with a clear goal of generating credits for companies abroad (Asiyanbi 2016). This is extremely harmful as it shifts power away from the communities that are heavily dependent on farming, hunting, and grazing, where they no longer have autonomy as corporations are securing profits. Offsets therefore create benefits for foreign corporations at the expense of locals.

CASE STUDY

A well-documented example of this is the Mai Ndombe REDD++ project in the Democratic Republic of Congo and other African countries in which they operate. This project claims to

protect roughly 300,000 hectares of rainforest and deliver communities with schools, medical clinics, and more (Wildlife Works / WRM n.d.-c). However, critics such as the World Rainforest Movement contend that projects such as these perpetuate past patterns of land appropriation by external actors.

These reports indicate the restrictions this project brings to local communities as they progressively lack more access to their own fishing grounds and agricultural areas which directly impacts food security and undermines economic independence, while developers and international buyers reap the benefits.

GLOBAL PARALLELS

This is not restricted to African countries; it is a global issue. In Latin America carbon market plantation schemes in Orinoquia have been proven to degrade land instead of restoring it. As stated by an Indigenous Sikuani, these companies do not serve as reforestation companies, as they have introduced invasive tree species in their territory, driving out what already grows there.

Those living in these areas have absolutely no agency on how they prefer the land to be used. This furthers the point that offset markets are similar to patterns of colonial style land control that persist today, where land is appropriated for colonial reserves, plantations, and mines.

This shows that foreign investors and polluters are accruing more benefit than the communities that have lived there for centuries. Villagers in Kenya have even reported feeling excluded from decision making about their own land which has directly led to negative externalities such as food insecurity because they are prohibited from grazing animals on this land through projects like the Kasigau Corridor project (World Agroforestry 2015).

In all these cases, companies benefit through the sale of carbon credits, earning billions in revenue while residents experience food insecurity. These human impacts are extremely critical as reducing grazing land immediately increases hunger. These restrictions on forest access negatively impact the locals ability to access land for cultural practices, farmland, and plants for medicine collection. This leaves women and children with more labor burdens as they are left to travel a further distance to find these farming spaces and resources while also facing displacement in extreme cases, intensifying poverty in these countries.

BURDEN ON LOW EMITTING NATIONS

To add on, the burden of climate mitigation has been left in the hands of countries that have contributed the least to climate change and global emissions. According to the United Nations fact sheet on climate change, Africa has contributed 3% of the global carbon dioxide emissions from energy and industrial sources. In 2000, their per-capital emissions stood at 0.8 tons compared to the global average of 3.8 tons (UNFCCC n.d.). Meanwhile, Africa has faced climate impacts such as floods, food insecurity, child labor, biodiversity loss and more.

MONITORING AND OVERSIGHT WEAKNESS

Monitoring and oversight have also been persistent issues, leaving several African countries at an obvious disadvantage. This is because offset projects require detailed measurements as developers are required to prove that emissions have been reduced. Due to this, technical expertise and detailed data collection is vital. Unfortunately, many African nations lack these vital means due to underfunding.

This lack of monitoring and oversight subjects African nations to developers seeking to gain profit and overstate just how much emissions were reduced in an area (Kauppi et al. 2020; Asiyanbi 2016). This leaves the environment at a severe risk while simultaneously perpetuating global inequalities.

NEED FOR STRUCTURAL REFORM

Offsets are undermining climate justice while placing costs on African nations already impacted by the effects of climate change (Bassey 2023a). However, if redesigned correctly, carbon markets can have a positive impact on many nations. To ensure sustainable development we must implement a new model that ensures

- projects are respecting land rights
- communities are receiving a reasonable share of revenue
- government regulation
- implementation of strong monitoring offsets

Without these reforms, offsets will continuously act as an extractive means rather than a climate mitigation tool.

AFRICAN LAND AUTONOMY PROTOCOL (ALAP) SOLUTION

To combat this issue, we must move from outsourced emission cuts to domestic emission cuts in these high polluting countries. To do so, there must be an implementation of a policy built on sovereignty and the rejection of extractive climate schemes masked as “environmental solutions” to ensure that nations in the Global North reduce their emissions instead of treating African nations as a carbon dump site. The African Land Autonomy Porotcol (ALAP) will

Grant communities with ownership over their own land

End external control over African ecosystems

Provide domestic African communities with the power to reject project of outside actors

Require foreign countries to cut emissions domestically before engaging with African nations

Protect land use for fishing, farming, and grazing industries

CONCLUSION

Offsets are often discussed as a means to solve climate change and reduce emissions in areas where it is cheapest to do so. This seems like a solid initiative on paper, but in practice, many African countries are caught in the crossfire, plagued with moral hazard, weak oversight/monitoring, permanence, and more. These issues are structural. Offsets lead to the extraction of African land to compensate for emissions produced in Western countries, essentially producing fictitious climate gains and distracting many from the urgent need for true climate finance and technological advancements (Bassey 2023a; Asiyanbi 2016). For these reasons, carbon offsets serve as greenwashing.

For carbon offsets to truly be effective and ethical, major reforms must be implemented to halt the creation of sacrificial zones where environmental harm is accumulating day by day.

CITATION

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